

NIYYAH PRESS · FREE CHAPTER



CHAPTER ONE

The Trade That Exposed Me

from The Trader and the Nafs

ABRIHYM AOBAD

The Trade That Exposed Me

I want to tell you about the worst forty minutes of my trading life. Not because they were expensive — though they were — but because of what they showed me. Things I'd spent years arranging my life so I'd never have to see.

It was a Tuesday. I remember because Tuesdays were supposed to be my disciplined days. I had a rule, in my own handwriting, taped to the bottom of my monitor where I couldn't pretend I hadn't read it: *Two losses and I'm done*. I'd written it after a brutal month. I meant it the way you mean things at two in the morning when the pain is still fresh — completely, with the certainty of a man who has finally learned.

First loss came in the opening half hour. Clean. Stop hit exactly where it belonged. Nothing wrong with the trade except that it didn't work, which happens to every trade ever taken. Small sting. *That's fine. Cost of doing business*.

I believed myself. First mistake.

Second loss, forty minutes later. Also clean. Also fine, in theory. But something had changed in the room, and the room was inside me. The first loss had been a fact. The second was an insult. I could feel the heat climbing the back of my neck — that specific flush you get when you've been embarrassed in front of people, except no one was there. Just me, a screen, and a number smaller than it had been an hour before.

The rule was right there. *Two losses and I'm done*.

I read it. Understand that. I didn't forget the rule. I didn't fail to see it. I looked straight at my own handwriting, the ink I'd pressed into the paper as a promise to myself, and a voice — calm, reasonable, almost kind — said:

Yes, but today is different.

That sentence. I've come to believe it has cost human beings more money, more years, more marriages and health and peace than almost any other arrangement of words in the language. *Today is different*. It's the password the lower self uses to get past the guard. And the guard, every single time, steps aside.

So I took a third trade. To "get back to even" — as though the market knew what even meant to me, as though there were a scoreboard that would reset if I just clicked enough. The third trade went against me almost at once. And here the man who wrote the rule vanished, and someone else sat down in his chair.

I moved my stop.

Sit with that, because if you trade, you already know exactly what I'm describing, and exactly how it feels, and you've probably never said it out loud to another human being. I had a stop loss. Placed correctly, at a level I'd chosen earlier with a clear mind. And as price approached it, I reached over and dragged it lower. Gave the trade "room to breathe." Gave myself permission. Price kept falling. I dragged it again. I wasn't trading anymore. I was negotiating with reality, and reality doesn't negotiate.

By the time it was over — forty minutes after that second loss — I'd lost more than in the previous three weeks combined. I sat in a silence that had a ringing in it. And the thought that arrived wasn't *what a bad trade*.

It was: *Who was that?*



Because that was the real horror. Not the money — I rebuilt the money. The horror was discovering there was someone living inside me I didn't know. Who didn't respect my rules. Who didn't care about my future. Who showed up only under heat, and who, in the moment that mattered most, was stronger than me.

I'd thought I was a disciplined person. I had evidence. I woke early. I kept commitments to other people. I could grind through boring work for hours.

And then a screen full of numbers reached into my chest and pulled out a stranger.

This is the first thing you need to understand, and everything else grows from it: **the market didn't create that person. It revealed him.**

He'd always been there. He was there when I ate the food I'd sworn off. There when I checked my phone for the ninth time mid-sentence with someone I loved. There every time I knew the right thing with total clarity and did the other thing and then explained to myself, intelligently, why the other thing was fine. The market didn't install him. It just turned up the voltage until I could no longer pretend he wasn't home.

This is why I say, and will keep saying until you're sick of it: **trading is one of the most honest mirrors a human being can stand in front of.**

A mirror doesn't flatter. It doesn't care about your self-image, your intentions, the story you tell at dinner about the kind of man you are. It shows what is there. And the market, more than almost any arena in modern life, refuses to let you hide. Your therapist can be charmed. Your spouse can be managed. Your own memory will quietly edit the footage to make you the hero. But your trading account keeps a record that doesn't lie, updated to the second, in a currency you can't argue with.

Every rule you break is a confession.

Every stop you move is a line from a diary you've been avoiding learning to read.



I could have walked away from that Tuesday and done what most traders do. Decided the problem was technical. Bought another course. Found another indicator. Refined the "system" and told myself the real issue was that my edge wasn't sharp enough.

This is the great escape hatch of the struggling trader, and it's comfortable precisely because it points the finger anywhere but at the self. *I need a better strategy* is a thought you can have for ten years without ever once being uncomfortable.

But I had moved my stop. That wasn't a strategy problem. My strategy was fine. I had overridden my strategy. The failure happened in the six inches between my brain and my hand — a place no charting software has ever reached.

So I started asking a different question. Not *what's wrong with my trading* but *what's wrong with me* — and then, more usefully, *what is the nature of this thing inside me that knows the right answer and chooses the wrong one?*

That question is older than markets. Older than money. Human beings have been losing this exact war — knowing the good and doing the harm — since the beginning, and asking why with the same bewildered shame I felt that Tuesday. The man who returns to the sin he wept over abandoning. The mother who screams at her child and hates herself before the echo dies. Same machinery. The market just runs the experiment faster, with money on the line, so the results come back in minutes instead of years.

When I went looking for who had the most precise map of this machinery, I didn't find it in modern psychology — though it has useful things to say, and we'll use them. I found the oldest, most detailed map in my own tradition: the Islamic science of the *nafs*, the self. Fourteen centuries of doing almost nothing but studying the gap between what a person knows and what a person does — naming its features, charting its tricks, mapping the road out.

The Qur'an doesn't describe the lower self gently. It calls it *al-nafs al-ammāra bi'l-sū'* — the self that *commands* you to evil. Not suggests. Not occasionally tempts. *Commands* — the word you'd use for a king issuing an order he fully expects obeyed. And the verse that names it is spoken not by a sinner but by one of the most self-controlled figures in all of scripture, the Prophet Yusuf, in a moment of staggering honesty: *"And I do not absolve my own self. Indeed the self is a persistent commander of evil, except those my Lord has mercy upon"* (Qur'an 12:53).

Read that again, because it dismantles something. A Prophet — a man who'd just refused one of the greatest temptations ever offered and chosen prison over yielding — refused to take the credit. He didn't say *look how strong I am*. He said *do not trust this self of mine; it commands evil; if I stood, it was mercy that held me up*.

If he wouldn't trust his nafs, what exactly made me think I could trust mine with a live position and a movable stop?



That Tuesday was the day I stopped trying to become a better trader and started trying to become a better master of myself. Not because I'd given up on profit — but because I'd finally understood the order of operations. The discipline was never going to come from a better strategy. The strategy would start working the day I became a man who could be trusted to follow it.

That's the journey this book will take you on. And I won't pretend it's mainly about money, because that's the same lie I told myself for years. It's about the self. It just uses the market as the mirror — because the mirror is merciless, and fast, and unlike almost everything else in your life, it will not let you lie.

So before we go further, I want you to do something most trading books would never ask.

Stop thinking about what the market did to you.

Start remembering what you did to yourself.

REFLECT

Don't answer fast. The fast answer is usually the nafs protecting itself.

1. Your single most *avoidable* trading decision — not your biggest loss, but the one where you knew better. What did you know, in that moment, that you chose to ignore?
2. What was the exact sentence you told yourself to justify it? Find the words. They matter more than you think.
3. Outside trading — in your eating, your prayers, your promises — where does that *same stranger* show up?
4. Have you been treating your trading problem as a knowledge problem or a self problem? Which is more comfortable for you, and why?

TRAIN · THE CONFESSION LOG

This week, keep a log. Not a trading journal — that records what the market did. This records what *you* did. Every time you break one of your own rules — any rule, however small — write three things, and only three:

- ◆ **What I knew** (the rule, already decided, before the heat)
- ◆ **What I did** (the action you actually took)
- ◆ **What I told myself** (the exact sentence that bridged the gap)

By the end of the week you'll notice something unsettling: the justifying sentences repeat. You've been getting robbed by the same three or four lies your whole life, in different clothes each time. We're going to learn their faces.

This was *Chapter One.*

The rest of the book names the stranger in full — the five diseases,
the lies they tell, and the one loop that beats them — and builds the
self that profit is finally safe to give.

Join the waitlist · thetraderandthenafs.com

THE TRADER AND THE NAFS — OUT SOON · NIYYAH PRESS